

ASSESSMENT BRIEF

Module title	Postgraduate Study and Research Methods
Module code	COM742
Module leader	Julie Mayers
Assessment title	Assignment 2 – Small Scale Research Study
Submission deadline	8 January 2026
Expected date for return of marks and feedback	Grades and feedback will be available on Moodle under the 'Assessment and Feedback' section. This will be made available within 15 working days and consist of annotations on the submission.
Module outcomes assessed	3. Synthesise and iterate a professional plan for a research study 4. Demonstrate a critical understanding of research methodologies in computing
Assessment weighting	60%
Word count	2500 words (+/- 10%)

Assessment task details

You are required to plan and conduct an appropriate research activity (the choice of which is at your discretion but should be discussed with your module tutor).

This activity may take several forms and could be, for example: a survey or questionnaire; piece of experimental work; observational study; desk-based literature review; secondary data analysis; systematic review; meta-analysis; interview; and so on. This activity should follow a clearly defined area of investigation that you will select. Initially, you must be clear in defining a hypothesis and/or question/s that your research activity will address using a suitable methodology.

Once your research has been carried out you should discuss and critically analyse your results/findings and draw conclusions from your activities.

Important Note: You are required to complete, and gain the endorsement of your lecturer for, an Ethical approval of research projects in taught programmes form prior to beginning any data collection or experimental work. This form can be found on the module Moodle page and should be submitted via email to the module tutor.

Responses from the tutor regarding ethical approval will be given via email. The request for ethical approval documentation is required.

Guidance and submission instructions

On submission of the academic report, a Turnitin check will be performed automatically, and unusually high levels of similarity will be flagged to the marker. By submitting this work, you confirm that you have read, understand and accept the university's regulations regarding plagiarism and agree to be dealt with accordingly if any such situation should arise.

The report should be submitted as a single Word or PDF document only, containing your assignment and a reference list. This report should be written using appropriate grammar and referencing skills; and it must be formatted appropriately and submitted online via the appropriate Turnitin submission link found on the module space. A template is provided on the module space for you to follow.

You will work on this assignment individually. In working individually, you must not share your ideas, data or other work product with other students.

All submitted work is expected to observe academic standards in terms of referencing (IEEE), academic writing, use of language etc. Failure to adhere to these instructions may result in your work being awarded a lower grade than it would otherwise deserve.

Hints and tips

In evaluating your research hypothesis, provided your methodology is sound, then proving your hypothesis, disproving it or finding the result inconclusive are equally valid research contributions.

In formulating your work, you may wish to consider the following:

- Existing data and results already available on the subject
- The independent and dependent variables
- Populations, sampling approach and sample sizes
- The types of variables you will work with
- A description and justification of the method you will use
- Ethical considerations
- Constraints and controls you have identified and/or assumed
- Data collection methods
- Techniques for data analysis and visualisation
- Statistical testing or analysis
- The reliability and validity of your research data

Make use of the various digital library subscriptions that the University has access to, particularly IEEE Xplore and the ACM Digital Library, as well as Google Scholar.

Try to be as concise and focused as you can be in producing your report. Do not add words for the sake of it. Make sure each word and sentence contribute something useful.

Marking and moderation
All grades/marks are indicative and may change when moderated – see page 5 for the marking criteria.
Penalties for late submission
Work submitted up to a week late without a valid reason can only gain a maximum of 40%. If an extension is required, then an Request for Extension to Assignment Deadline Form must be completed and agreed prior to the submission date. Any work submitted more than a week late without a valid reason may be read but will not be marked.
Support arrangements
Support will be provided via Moodle, lectures, and MS Teams. If students have any special requirements, they are advised to inform the lecturer. For additional support see the Learning Skills department. Here you can access the Academic Skills Tutors, Digital Learning Facilitators, and Academic Support Librarians.

Employability Skills Applied	
On successful completion of this module, a student will have had opportunities to demonstrate achievement of the following Employability Skills: Tick all that apply.	
CORE ATTRIBUTES	
Engaged	✓
Creative	✓
Enterprising	
Ethical	✓
KEY ATTITUDES	
Commitment	
Curiosity	✓
Resilient	✓
Confidence	✓
Adaptability	✓
PRACTICAL SKILLSETS	
Digital fluency	✓
Organisation	✓
Leadership and team working	
Critical thinking	✓
Emotional intelligence	✓
Communication	✓

Marking Criteria						
ELEMENT	ASSESSMENT TASK	<40	40%+	50%+	60%+	70%+
Hypothesis/research questions Weighting 15%	Within the introduction provide a clear and well-defined hypothesis/questions that your study will address	Insufficient or inappropriate hypothesis/research questions	Mainly reasonable hypothesis/research questions – areas that are unclear or lack definition	Good consideration of hypothesis/research questions good level of clarity and definition	A very good consideration of hypothesis/research questions good level of clarity and definition	Excellent consideration of hypothesis/research questions with an excellent level of clarity and definition
Research method and planning Weighting 20%	Relevant research method applied and justified	Insufficient or inappropriate research method/plan	Mainly reasonable research method/ plan	A good research method/plan with limited justification	A very relevant research method /plan with a good level of justification	A well-considered research method plan with excellent justification
Results and findings Weighting 10%	Clear and well-defined results/findings have been developed	Limited results/findings have been displayed	Results/Findings are organised in a clear manner.	A good set of results/findings have been organised in a clear manner.	A very good set of results/findings have been organised in a clear manner.	An excellent set of results/findings have been organised in a clear manner.
Critical analysis and discussion Weighting 30%	Critical analysis and discussion of your research	Insufficient or inaccurate critical analysis/discussion	A mainly reasonable critical analysis/discussion with significant inaccuracies in areas	A good critical analysis/discussion with minor inaccuracies in areas	A very good critical analysis/discussion with a good level of accuracy	An excellent, professional and accurate critical analysis and discussion
Conclusion Weighting 15%	Logical conclusions to be drawn from the discussion by proving or disproving the hypothesis, or finding the result inconclusive	Insufficient conclusions or mainly non-sequiturs drawn.	An appropriate conclusion is drawn	A good conclusion is drawn linking to the hypothesis/questions	A very good conclusion is drawn linking to the hypothesis/questions	An excellent and logical conclusion is drawn linking to the hypothesis/questions
Presentation Weighing 5%	Present your work in a clear and professional manner following the template	Insufficient or inappropriate presentation	Reasonable level of presentation	A good presentation of your work	A very good presentation of your work	An excellent presentation of your work.
Reference base Weighting 5%	Provide a suitable set of verifiable sources to support your discussion	Inadequate or inappropriate reference base	Adequate reference base in terms of size and focus	A good reference base in terms of size and focus.	A very good reference base in terms of size and focus	Excellent reference base in terms of size and focus